

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD

The Drum and the Ball

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The Drum and the Ball

Lamine's Journal

[AUTHOR NAME]

[PUBLISHER]

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A work of fiction. See “A Note on the Story” at the back of the book for what is invented and what is real.

First edition, 2026. · Story edition

ISBN [ISBN]

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PART ONE

The Patched Ball



Chapters 1–4

CHAPTER ONE

The Seam That Gave Out

Monday, February 5, 2024



The ball split its third seam right as I was about to score. I had already picked my corner. Left of Amadou, where he always dives a little too late because he shuts his eyes before every shot. My foot swung. The ball made a sound like a plastic bag getting crumpled.

PFFFRRT.

It lay down in the dust two meters from the goal.

Moussa looked at the ball. Then at my foot. Then at the ball again.

“Beautiful shot,” he said. “You killed our best player.”

I threw a handful of dirt at him. He was still laughing when Awa came tearing around the back of the school with two empty water jugs.

“Mom wants you.”

The three most dangerous words in Bambali.

“Tell her I’m coming.”

“She said now.”

“Now can mean five minutes from now.”

“She said you’d say that.”

Moussa sat down in the dust to examine the wound. A strip of black plastic had peeled off. Under the layers of tape, you could see the gray cloth we’d added last week.



“Maybe Idrissa can sew it back up,” he said.

“Tonight?”

“If his mom lets him use the big needle.”

“Lamine!”

This time it wasn’t Awa. Mom’s voice had crossed our yard, the school wall, and probably half the village.

I picked up the ball.

“I’ll keep it,” Moussa said.

“Why?”

“Because if your father sees it like this, he’ll say all we ever do is break things.”

His imitation of Baba was terrible. My father has a deep voice that can hush a whole courtyard. Moussa sounded like a goat with a cold.

I still didn’t laugh.

Baba is a griot. At naming ceremonies, weddings, and big celebrations, he tells the history of families and recites their lineages to the beat of his drum. He hates finding our soccer stuff in the way. According to him, a ball has no business near the instruments, the ceremony mats, or the notebooks where he keeps family genealogies. According to me, a ball doesn’t get to choose where somebody puts it.

This one had already been threatened with the trash twice. Even so, I didn’t want it spending the night anywhere but at my house, not even at Moussa’s. I just had to hide it well.

So I slipped it into my school bag.

Bad idea.

I knew it the second I did it.

I knew this would end badly. I did it anyway.

“Five minutes,” I told Moussa. “I’ll run my errand and come right back. We’ll find Idrissa and fix it.”

“You promised to help your mom.”

“I’m going to help her.”

“And you promised to practice with us.”

“I’ll do both.”

Moussa shrugged. That shrug meant: *Someday you’ll find out a day doesn’t have forty hours in it.* He lets his shoulders

do a lot of his talking. It's annoying, especially when they're right.

I ran home with the bag thumping against my back.

In the courtyard, Mom had lined up three basins: onions, peanuts, tomatoes. She had knotted her blue pagne above her waist and was holding her phone between her shoulder and her ear.

"Yes," she was saying. "I'll be there before three. Save me the two sacks. Yes. Two."

She saw me.

She stopped talking.

That silence was worse than the voice that had crossed the village.

"Your uncle's bike has been ready for twenty minutes," she said after she hung up. "I asked you to take the small basin to Auntie Mariama."

"I know."

"You know, but you're not here."

"The ball ripped."

I could have kept that to myself. It just came out.

Mom looked at my bag. A round lump was stretching the cloth.

"And you put it in with your notebooks?"

"So Baba won't throw it out."

"Your father doesn't throw your things out."

She paused.

"He threatens a lot. That's different."

I almost smiled. She didn't.

She set the small basin on the bike rack and tied it down with a piece of rope.

“I had a meeting with a supplier in Bounkiling. Your uncle was supposed to take me on his motorbike after the delivery. Now I’m going to be late.”

“I can pedal fast.”

“Speed isn’t what gets a promise there on time.”

There it was. A sentence for grownups.

Grownups own hundreds of them. They keep them somewhere behind their teeth and pull them out exactly when you have nothing to say back.

I got on the bike.

The small basin wasn’t heavy. That made it worse. If it had weighed fifty kilos, I could have told myself I was brave. Instead I was pedaling along with three tomatoes, some onions, and my shame.

At Auntie Mariama’s, nobody applauded when I showed up. She checked the tomatoes, paid Mom by phone, and asked:

“Did you run all the way here?”

“I biked.”

“You look like you crossed the whole of Senegal.”

I was dripping with sweat.

When I got back, Mom was gone. The big basin of peanuts was gone too. Awa was drawing squares in the sand with a stick.

“She missed her ride with Uncle Alioune,” she announced.

“Where is she?”

“At the market. She’s going to try to buy here.”

“I know what ‘at the market’ means.”

“Then why are you asking?”

I hate it when Awa is seven years old and right at the same time.

I wanted to head back behind the school, but Baba was sitting under the awning. In front of him were an open notebook, his drum under a cloth, and a cup of tea gone cold.

“Lamine.”

One word. My day was over.

I sat down across from him.

“Recite the three branches after Samba NDiop.”

The ball was pushing against the zipper of my bag.

“Mbaye, Assane, and...”

Nothing.

The third name was in there somewhere. It had decided to hide, exactly like my ball.

Baba waited.

“Abdoulaye,” he said at last.

“I knew that.”

“Knowing it after the answer is a great talent.”

He didn’t yell. I almost wished he had. When Baba yells, you can get mad at the noise. When he talks softly, every word lands exactly where it belongs.

“Tomorrow you’ll come with me to the Fatys’,” he went on. “We have to get ready for Saturday’s ceremony.”

“Tomorrow we’re fixing the ball.”

“‘We’?”

“Moussa, Idrissa, and me.”

Baba looked at the bag.

“You can fix a ball and learn a name in the same lifetime.”

I looked down. This grownup sentence was even more annoying than the last one, because it sounded like what I'd told Moussa: I'll do both.

That evening, Mom came home with less than she'd planned to buy. She didn't say what she'd missed. She put away her bills, wrote two numbers in her account book, and asked Awa to wash the tomatoes.

To me, all she said was:

"Tomorrow you're coming with us to get water before school."

I didn't argue.

Now everyone's asleep. The ball is under my bed. Madame Diouf gave us this journal today for French class. She said:

"Don't write to sound interesting. Write what keeps you up at night. Afterward, you'll choose what you share."

I wanted to start with: "My name is Lamine NDiop, I'm twelve years old, and I'm going to be a professional soccer player."

But what's keeping me up tonight is a split seam.

And Mom's account book, closing without a sound.

CHAPTER TWO

Two Hours of Water

Wednesday, February 7, 2024



This morning, Awa decided she was big enough to carry the yellow basin.

She isn't.

I knew it. Mom knew it. The neighbor's rooster probably knew it too.

Only Awa didn't know it.

"Take the small jug," I said.

"The small one's for babies."

"No. The small one's for people who want to get home with water instead of giving the path a bath."

She stuck her tongue out at me and set the basin on her head, on a piece of cloth rolled into a ring. She walked slowly, arms up, as proud as if all of Bambali had come to see her crowned.

We were almost home.

Almost.

Her foot slid on a stone. The basin tipped. Awa tried to catch it, which only helped the water pick a side to fall on.

A whole wave of it spilled into the dust.

For one second, we both stood there watching the ground drink our work.

Then I exploded.

“I told you to take the small one! Now we have to go back! I was supposed to meet Moussa!”

Awa’s face shut like a door.

She didn’t cry. If she had cried, I would have known what to do: roll my eyes, sigh, and end up admitting she was half right. But she just set the empty basin upright again.

“When the ball calls you, you run,” she said. “When it’s us, you show up late.”

She headed back toward the water point.

I stayed planted in front of the puddle, which was already disappearing.

Little sisters should not be allowed to borrow your mother’s sentences and improve them.

I caught up with Awa. We made the trip again. This time I carried the yellow basin and she took the small jug. Neither of us said a word.



At home, Mom checked the time.

“You two took a long time.”

“Awa spilled...”

I stopped.

Awa was looking at me.

“We spilled a basin,” I said instead.

That wasn’t completely true. It wasn’t completely false either. I had picked the big basin for her last night when I set out the containers. I thought it would save us a trip.

Mom didn’t ask any questions. She handed me the bread and poured the tea.

“Eat. You’re going to be late.”

Moussa was waiting for me at the crossroads with my ball under his arm.

It was round.

Well, almost round. Let’s say it had found the hope of becoming round again.

“Idrissa did that?”

“His mom sewed the inside. He wrapped the tape back around.”

He tossed me the ball. I trapped it with my right foot.

It bounced off sideways and hit a chicken.

The chicken complained very loudly.

“It still has a personality,” Moussa said.

“Let’s call it a technical ball.”

“Sure. It takes a lot of technique to guess where it’s going.”

On the way to school, I told him about the basin. Not what Awa said. Just the spilled water.

“You missed the start of practice for that?”

“Yeah.”

“It’s no big deal.”

“You’re only saying that because you weren’t the one carrying it.”

Moussa slowed down.

“I’m saying it because we played without you this morning.”

“With who?”

“Souleymane, Idrissa, Amadou, and two little kids.”

“You practiced with the little kids?”

“We played. That’s not the same.”

I felt something sharp poke me right under the ribs. I thought they’d wait for me. Not all day, obviously. But a little. Enough for my absence to leave a hole.

“Who scored?” I asked.

“Souleymane. Three times.”

The poke went in deeper.

At school, Madame Diouf asked us to choose a passage from our journal to read to the person sitting next to us.

I was sitting next to Fatou.

Of course.

Fatou always gets the best grades in French. She writes in straight lines even without lines. Her notebook looks like it was printed by a machine with very good manners.

I put my arm over my page.

“You have to read it,” she said.

“I know.”

“Then why are you hiding it?”

“I’m building suspense.”

She waited.

Fatou knows how to wait in a way that makes you do what she wants.

I read about the ripped ball, Mom being late, and the account book closing. Not all of it. I skipped the part where I forget Abdoulaye. I wasn’t about to hand out all my humiliations on the same day.

When I finished, Fatou didn’t laugh.

“How much did your mom lose?”

“I don’t know if she lost anything.”

“You wrote that she bought less.”

“That doesn’t mean...”

I stopped.

“Do you always ask questions like that?”

“Only when someone writes down the answer and pretends not to see it.”

After school, I met the team behind the building. Souleymane was bouncing the ball on his thigh. Once. Twice.

Three times. The fourth bounce smacked him in the chin.

I enjoyed that very much.

“Finally,” he said. “The star has arrived.”

“I was in class.”

“So were we.”

Moussa set down four sandals to make two goals. We played two against three. I tried to make up for lost time in a single play.

Bad idea number two of the week.

I dribbled past Amadou, then Idrissa. I could have passed to Moussa. I kept going. The ball hit a bump, changed direction, and rolled right to Souleymane, who scored in our empty goal.

“Technical ball,” Moussa muttered.

I pretended I didn’t hear.

On the next play, I kept the ball again. And again.

“Pass!” Moussa shouted.

“Get open!”

“I’ve been open the whole time!”

He had.

I shot anyway.

Wide.

We lost five to three. I scored two of our three. So on the way home, I kept telling myself it wasn’t really my fault.

Numbers are handy that way. You get to pick which ones you look at.

In front of the house, Awa was playing with the empty jug. She was nudging it with her foot like a ball.

“You’re going to break it,” I said.

She picked it up without answering.

I went inside, then came back out.

“Awa.”

She kept drawing a circle in the dust.

“I’m sorry I yelled.”

No answer.

“And that I said it was your fault.”

She looked up.

“It was my fault.”

“The basin, yes. Being late, no. I should have been there earlier.”

She thought about it for a very long time for a person who is seven.

“Okay.”

“Okay what?”

“Okay, you’re allowed to be sorry.”

She walked off with the jug.

I don’t think that’s exactly the same as forgiving someone.

Tonight, I asked Mom if she lost money on Monday.

She was packing peanuts into little bags.

“I lost a good price,” she said. “Not my whole business.”

“Because of me?”

“Because of the delay. You helped cause it.”

She handed me a bag.

“Tie this one.”

I sat down next to her. We made thirty-two of them. She checked every knot by giving it a tug.

“A dream takes time, Lamine,” she said. “If you’re not careful, yours will take other people’s time too.”

I waited for the rest.

She didn't add any.

Grownups should do that more often.

Outside, Baba tapped three times on the wood of his drum, still under its cloth.

DOUM. DOUM-DOUM.

I pulled on the knot of my bag.

It held.

CHAPTER THREE

The Forgotten Name

Saturday, February 10, 2024



Today I saved Baba.
He'll never put it that way.
I probably won't either.
But that's what happened.

We went to the Fatys' house before the sun was high. A ceremony was going to bring the families together in the big courtyard. Plastic chairs stood in rows under stretched awnings. The women were finishing the food. Kids ran between the grownups' legs until an auntie shooed them off, and then they came back in from another side.

Baba wore a big boubou the color of sand. I had on my big brother Ousmane's, since he left for Dakar to learn to be a mechanic. His boubou gives me the sleeves of a giant.

Under my arm, I held the notebook of names.

"Don't squeeze it like a ball," Baba said.

"I don't squeeze my ball like that."

"That's why it keeps splitting open."

Point for him.

For three days, we'd been going over the branches of the Faty family. The names kept getting tangled in my head. One Mamadou had two sons, and one of them was also named Mamadou. There were also two Ibrahimas, three Mariamas, and a Samba you absolutely must not mix up with the other Samba.

Families should give some warning before they hand out the same name to several people.

Baba never got them wrong.

That's what I thought, anyway.

When his turn came, the courtyard grew quieter little by little. He took the cloth off his drum. The wood shone where his hands have touched it for years. A man took his place beside him. An old lady asked for her chair to be moved closer.

Baba started in a low voice.

He doesn't recite names like a class roll. He sets them into the rhythm. One name calls up the next. A birth answers a marriage. A short story opens up and then circles back to the family sitting in front of him.

I know the moment when people stop moving.

Even the kids watch.

Sometimes I hate to admit it, but Baba is really good.

I was following along in the notebook with my finger. Everything was going fine until a man came in late and walked across the courtyard in front of him. Chairs scraped the ground. Someone called his name. A woman got up to hug him.

Baba kept going.

Then his hand stopped.

Only for a second.

Maybe less.

But I saw it.

His finger hung in the air above the drumhead. The next name wasn't coming.

In the courtyard, nobody had caught on yet. The chatter the latecomer had started covered the gap.

I had the name right in front of me: **Bakary Faty**.

I could have whispered it.

But the silence between Baba and me wasn't made for a word. It was waiting for something else. I don't know how I understood that.

With my fingers against the cover of the notebook, I picked up the pattern he'd been playing since the beginning.

DOUM. DOUM-DOUM. PA.

Very softly.

Baba's eyes turned toward me.



I did it again.

DOUM. DOUM-DOUM. PA.

His finger came back down on the drumhead.

“Bakary,” he called out, “son of Moussa, whose canoe came home even when the sky changed its mind...”

The rhythm took off again.

Nobody noticed the crack.

Except maybe Yaye Khady, my grandmother, Baba’s mother, who was sitting in the second row. She looked at me and raised her left eyebrow. For her, that’s the same as a long speech.

After the ceremony, lots of people held Baba back. They shook his hand, corrected a memory, added another one. One man said the canoe story had happened in a different season. A woman insisted it hadn’t, because she’d been there.

I liked that argument.

It proved that memories don’t sit up straight in a notebook. They move. They object. Each one wants its own place.

On the way home, Baba didn’t say anything until we reached the big kapok tree.

I figured he wasn’t going to talk about what had happened.

“You heard where I got lost,” he said.

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Your finger stopped.”

“Not my hands. The rhythm.”

I waited.

“You heard the rhythm break,” he went on. “And you knew where to pick it back up.”

I looked at my sandals.

A compliment from Baba usually sounds like the start of a new job.

“Starting Monday, we’ll work an extra half hour every evening.”

There it was.

“Baba...”

“What you did isn’t something you learn only from notebooks.”

“I have practice.”

“Your practice starts at five. We’ll work before that.”

“I have homework too.”

“Then you’ll organize your time.”

“And what if I don’t want to do it the way you do?”

He stopped walking.

The path was red and dry. A bicycle passed us, loaded with two sacks. Farther along, a radio in a little shop was calling a soccer game.

“You don’t know yet what you want,” Baba said.

“Yes, I do. I want to play.”

“Play where?”

“For a real club. In Dakar first. After that, I don’t know. Farther. Like Sadio Mané.”

“And how many boys in Bambali want the same thing?”

“A lot.”

“How many make it?”

“I don’t know.”

“Neither do I.”

His answer surprised me. I'd expected him to make up a number to prove I was wrong.

"But I know what our family can give you," he added.

"And I know what soccer gives me."

"What?"

I opened my mouth.

The answer should have been easy.

Speed. Joy. The moment the ball lands exactly where you pictured it. Moussa's shout. The dust. The feeling that the field gets bigger as soon as you start to run.

It was all in my head.

None of it came out right.

"It's different," I said.

Baba started walking again.

"Different doesn't mean enemy."

Another sentence for grownups.

This time, I couldn't manage to hate it all the way.

At home, Yaye Khady called me over while Baba was putting his drum away.

"He forgot Bakary," I whispered.

"He didn't forget Bakary."

"Yes, he did."

"He lost the road to Bakary. That's not the same thing."

"And I found it."

"Yes."

She was crumbling leaves between her fingers for tea.

"Don't make that face. Your father was proud."

"That's exactly the problem."

Yaye Khady laughed so loud that Baba looked over at us.

"Are you afraid he'll find out you're his son?"

"I know I'm his son."

“Then find out you can be his son in more than one way.”

I told her she sounded like a mysterious old lady.

She told me she was an old lady and the mystery came free.

This afternoon, I met up with the others behind the school. Our repaired ball still bounced crooked. I closed my eyes for a second while Moussa tapped it gently with his foot.

POC. POC-POC.

It wasn't Baba's rhythm.

Not exactly.

But when Moussa sped up, I knew before I even looked up that he was going to pass to me.

I trapped it.

And for once, the ball didn't take off toward a chicken.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Red Laces

Tuesday, February 13, 2024



Moussa and I had a fight over a shoelace.
That's not true.

We had a fight over the ball, over Souleymane, over me being late, over him being late, over our families, over a pair of shoes I don't have, and over a bunch of things we never said.

The shoelace just happened to be at the scene of the crime.

It all started at recess.

We were playing behind the classroom building with the repaired ball. Two stones marked each goal. Fatou was sitting in the shade with her math notebook, which didn't stop her from watching every single play.

I got a pass from Idrissa. The ball bounced off the seam and rolled away from my foot.

Souleymane took it.

“Even your ball doesn’t want to play with you anymore,” he said.

“Give it.”

“Come get it.”

I charged. He knocked the ball right between my legs.

Everyone yelled.

Even Fatou looked up.

I chased Souleymane down, got the ball back, and scored. I could have stopped there.

Instead, I turned toward him and spread my arms wide.

“What were you saying?”

“That you run fast when your feelings are hurt.”

Moussa came to get the ball out of the goal.

“Can we play instead of talking?”

“Tell him that.”

“I’m telling both of you.”

“So you always take Souleymane’s side now?”

Moussa looked at me as if the question smelled bad.

“I’m taking the side of the few minutes we have left.”

We started again. Two plays later, my left shoelace came undone. I stepped on it and landed on my hands.

Souleymane laughed again.

That lace was already too short. It had snapped last month, and I’d tied the two pieces together in the middle. My shoes stayed on mostly because my feet had learned not to move around much inside them.

Moussa crouched down.

“You need a new one.”

“Thanks, Doctor Shoelace.”

“I’ve got a pair at home.”

“I don’t need your stuff.”

“I didn’t say you needed it.”

“Then why are you saying it?”

He stood up.

“Because your shoes are falling apart.”

“Worry about the ball instead. You’re the one who said it was impossible to control.”

“It is.”

“Only for people who can’t play.”

Moussa dropped the ball between us.

“You know what, Lamine? Sometimes you act like everything we have is too small for you.”

That sentence hit me harder than Souleymane’s nutmeg.

“And you,” I answered, “act like not wanting anything too much will keep you from losing.”

His face changed.

I could have stopped.

Again.

“You miss half our practices and then you hand out advice. If you’d rather haul sacks for your uncle, just say so.”

The silence fell all around us.

I knew Moussa’s uncle needed him some evenings at the workshop. I also knew why: his apprentice had quit, and he couldn’t afford to pay someone new right away.

Moussa had only told me.

And I had just thrown it into the middle of the field.

“At least when I promise to be somewhere, I’m there,” he said.

He set the ball at my feet and walked away.

The bell rang almost right after.

Nobody said a word on the way back to class.

During the lesson, Madame Diouf was explaining the different points of view in a story. I stared at the back of Moussa's neck two rows ahead of me.

From my point of view, he started it.

From his, I started it.

From Fatou's point of view, we were probably two idiots who had wasted the whole recess.

After school, Moussa wasn't at the crossroads.

I went behind the school. Idrissa and Amadou were there. Souleymane too.

"Isn't he coming?" I asked.

Idrissa shrugged.

"Workshop."

That one word was enough.

We started without him. I played fast, too fast. Every pass felt like an argument I wanted to win. After twenty minutes, my shoelace broke for good.

My shoe gaped open like a mouth.

"You could play barefoot," Amadou offered.

The field had been cleared the week before, but little pebbles were still around. I took my shoes off anyway.

On my first sprint, a stone jabbed my heel. Nothing serious. Just enough to make me even madder.

We quit before dark.

On the walk home, I tried to figure out how to talk to Moussa.

I came up with twelve ways.

In the first one, I said, "Sorry."

In the second: “You made me mad.”

In the third: “I didn’t mean what I said.”

That one was a lie. When I said it, I meant it. That’s the worst part about some words. They’re true for one second, and they keep hurting for a lot longer.

When I got to his house, his aunt told me he was still at the workshop.

I didn’t have the courage to go there.

I went home.

At our house, Baba was practicing a rhythm for Saturday. He asked me to sit with him. I said I had homework.

For the first time in my life, that excuse was almost true.

I opened my math notebook. The numbers turned into shoelaces, balls, and Moussa’s closed face.

An hour later, somebody flicked a pebble against the shutter.

I went outside.

Moussa was waiting by the wall.

He was holding two red laces.

Not tomato red. Darker. Worn at the tips, but strong.

“My cousin had these in her old shoes,” he said. “They’re too long, so you’ll have to wrap them around twice.”

“Moussa...”

“I don’t want you getting hurt before I get the chance to beat you myself.”

He held out the laces.



I didn't take them right away.

"What I said about your uncle..."

"That was low."

"Yeah."

"And you said it in front of everybody."

"Yeah."

I wanted to add that he'd hurt me too. That his line about things being too small had found exactly the spot where it hurts. But an apology with a "you did it too" in it isn't really an apology anymore. It's an argument wearing a clean shirt.

"You told that to me," I said. "I had no right to repeat it."

He looked down at the laces in his hand.

"No, you didn't."

"I'm sorry."

Moussa nodded once.

"I don't completely forgive you yet."

“Are you still coming tomorrow?”

“Maybe.”

“Does that mean yes?”

“It means maybe.”

He finally handed me the laces.

“And this doesn’t fix everything,” he added.

“I know.”

“Good.”

He left.

I laced up my shoes under the lamp. The laces really were too long. I wrapped them around twice, like he said.

Baba stopped in the doorway.

“They look like two streaks of fire.”

“They’re just shoelaces.”

“Things can be two things at once.”

He walked off before I could answer.

I think Baba spies on Yaye Khady so he can steal her mysterious sentences.

Tomorrow I’ll play in the red laces.

Maybe Moussa will come.

And for once, I know that a gift doesn’t mean everything is fixed.

It just means something is still holding.

PART TWO

The Shadow of a Homecoming



Chapters 5–8

CHAPTER FIVE

Malang's Name

Friday, February 16, 2024



This morning, Malang's name got to school before Madame Diouf did.

It was already in the schoolyard, in Souleymane's mouth.

"He's coming with three cars."

"Two," Idrissa corrected.

"Three. My cousin heard it yesterday."

"You can't hear a car the day before it comes," Fatou said.

"Not the car. The news."

"Then say the news, not the engine."

Souleymane ignored her. He stood in the middle of us like a sportscaster before a final.

"Malang gets here Sunday for his cousin's wedding. He's staying almost three weeks. He's bringing shoes, jerseys, and maybe balls."

"For who?" Amadou asked.

Souleymane put on a mysterious face.

“For the ones who deserve them.”

That sentence did exactly what he wanted it to. Everybody started talking at once.

Malang Dramé doesn’t come back to Bambali very often. He lives in Dakar, works in construction, and spends part of the year on building sites in other cities. When he comes home, the grownups ask him for news about people I don’t know, and the kids try to walk close to him, as if success might fall out of his pocket.

Mostly, I was thinking about Cheikh.

“Is he coming too?” I asked.

Souleymane grinned.

“Scared?”

“I asked a question.”

“Yes, he’s coming.”

My stomach did a stupid little flip.

Cheikh and I used to play together before he left for the academy. Not “together” the way Moussa and I play together. Cheikh always wanted to pick the teams, the positions, how many goals it took to win, and sometimes even which way the wind blew. But he knew how to invent impossible challenges.

Once, we tried to keep the ball in the air until the call to prayer was over. We lost after seventeen touches and claimed the muezzin had started too early.

Another time, Cheikh missed a shot so badly that the ball landed in a washtub. He made me swear never to tell anyone.

I never told.

Until now, but a journal doesn't count.

"Lamine?"

Moussa was looking at me.

"What?"

"Your head went somewhere."

"It's right here."

"No. That's just your face."

The bell rang. During class, Madame Diouf had to ask Souleymane twice to stop drawing cars in the margins. I only drew one shoe. A soccer cleat with neat rows of studs and laces short enough that you wouldn't need to wrap them twice.

I scribbled it out before Fatou could see it.

After Friday prayers, the whole village had already switched speeds. In front of the Fatys' house, men were putting up an awning for the wedding. Chairs arrived stacked on a cart. A woman was talking on the phone while directing three boys who were carrying basins.

Mom had gotten an order of onions, chili peppers, and peanuts for the wedding kitchen.

"Sunday, Monday, and Tuesday, you're helping me," she said. "No disappearing behind the school until the deliveries are done."

"Sunday too?"

"People don't stop eating just because you own a ball."

"But Malang gets here Sunday."

"Malang can arrive without you."

I think Mom is the only person in Bambali who could hear that the president was coming and ask first how many people she'd need to feed.

Baba walked in at that exact moment with a list of names for the ceremony.

“Malang’s coming Sunday,” I told him.

“I know.”

“With Cheikh.”

“I know that too.”

“Everybody in this house knows everything before I do.”

“That’s because we listen when other people talk,” Awa said.

Nobody had asked her.

In the evening, we played behind the school. Our little field isn’t the village stadium, with the new turf Sadio Mané paid for in January. That one takes planning, grownups, and sometimes permission. Ours is simpler: a strip of red dirt next to the school, close enough that someone can call us when a chore is waiting.

It isn’t perfect, but it’s exactly the right distance from our lives.

Moussa had on his old shoes. My red laces held mine tight.

“Are you going to show him?” he asked.

“Show him what?”

“That you play better than before.”

“I don’t have anything to show him.”

Moussa trapped the ball with the inside of his foot.

“Good.”

“‘Good’ what?”

“Nothing.”

“Say it.”

“You just did the voice.”

“What voice?”

“The one that says, ‘I have nothing to prove,’ while your whole body is already getting the proof ready.”

I stole the ball from him.

“Cheikh plays at an academy. I play here. That doesn’t mean anything.”

“Exactly.”

“But if he thinks he can come back and treat us like little kids...”

“Lamine.”

I stopped.

Moussa hadn’t forgotten our fight. Neither had I. The laces held my shoes together, not our whole friendship.

“Okay,” I said. “Even if he plays better, that doesn’t mean we’re worth nothing.”

“Promise?”

“Promise.”

“Even if he has new shoes?”

“They’re shoes, not wings.”

Moussa held out his hand.

I slapped it.

At that moment, the promise seemed really easy.

Cheikh hadn’t even arrived yet.

CHAPTER SIX

The White Cleats

Sunday, February 18, 2024



Cheikh got out of the car holding a pair of white cleats.
Not wearing them.

Holding them.

As if he knew everybody had to see them before they even touched the ground.

Two cars, not three. Idrissa won. Souleymane claimed the third one would come later with the luggage.

The Fatys' courtyard was packed. Grownups were greeting Malang, kids were running around the cars, and somebody was video calling an aunt who'd stayed in Dakar so she could watch the arrival. Smells of onion, hot oil, and spiced meat drifted out of the kitchen.

I had a sack of peanuts on my shoulder.

Of course.

Mom had parked me near her table so I could carry the orders to the kitchen. I'd already made six trips. My arms

smelled like dust and salt. Cheikh was wearing a blue track-suit without a single stain on it.

He had grown.

Not a lot. Just enough for me to notice, and for that to bug me.

Malang greeted the elders first. There was nothing of a king or a famous athlete about him. He laughed loudly, hugged a lot of people, answered several questions at once, and kept looking around for someone. When he spotted Baba, he came straight over.

“Boubacar! They tell me you tell stories even better than before.”

“That’s because people forget faster,” Baba answered.

They laughed.

Cheikh stood a little behind Malang, spinning a key between his fingers.

I walked over.

“Hey.”

He looked at my face, then at the sack on my shoulder.

“Lamine.”

He said my name as if he were checking an answer.

“You still remember,” I said.

“Of course.”

We shook hands. His palm was dry. Mine was covered in peanut dust.

“You still play behind the school?” he asked.

“Yeah.”

“With the plastic ball?”

“It isn’t only plastic.”

“Oh. So it’s improved too.”

I felt a comeback rising.

And you, still kicking balls into washtubs?

Baba was standing right next to us. So was Malang. The grownups had just seen each other again after months apart. I didn't want to turn their welcome into a schoolyard fight.

So I swallowed my sentence.

"Come by sometime," I said. "You'll see."

Cheikh smiled.

"Maybe."

The same word Moussa uses, but not the same sound. In Moussa's mouth, *maybe* meant he was leaving a door open a crack. In Cheikh's, the door was very tall, and he was looking down at us from the balcony.

"Come this afternoon," Souleymane called from behind me. "At four."

I hadn't seen him come up.

Cheikh looked Souleymane over, then my shoes. The red laces stuck out a little even though I'd wrapped them twice.

"Fine," he said. "If I have time."

He went off with Malang.

"If I have time,'" Souleymane repeated. "Does he think he's a government minister?"

"You didn't have to invite him."

"You invited him before I did."

"I said 'come by sometime.'"

"That's an invitation using more scared words."

I handed him the sack of peanuts.

"Here. Since you're so brave."

At four o'clock, Cheikh wasn't there.

At ten after four, still no.

At twenty after, Souleymane kept saying he wasn't coming. At twenty-two after, a motorbike stopped near the path. Cheikh climbed off. An older boy had given him the ride.

He had changed clothes.

And he had put on the white cleats.

The field went silent for about three seconds. After that, everyone pretended not to look at them.

They were so clean they looked brand new. Maybe they were. I didn't recognize the brand, and I decided I didn't care.

I cared a whole lot.

"How many are you playing?" Cheikh asked.

"Three against three," Moussa said.

"On that?"

He was looking at our field.

"No, on the moon," I said.

His smile moved about a millimeter.

He set a bag down on the sideline. He took out a ball that was almost new. Not shiny, not special, but round. Perfectly round.

Amadou whispered:

"It can roll straight."

Nobody answered, because we were all thinking the same thing.

Cheikh started juggling. Right foot, left foot, thigh, shoulder. The ball never went too high. It obeyed him as if the two of them had signed a contract.

“Are we playing?” Moussa asked.

Cheikh let the ball drop and pinned it under the sole of his shoe.

“Warm up first.”

Souleymane rolled his eyes.

“We’re already warm.”

“Sweating isn’t the same as being warmed up.”

I almost laughed. Souleymane almost did too, but he held it in.

Cheikh showed us two simple exercises. Not like a teacher. Like someone who wanted us to see that he knew. We followed along anyway. Monsieur Diatta, our gym teacher, is always telling us to get our ankles and knees ready before we play. We almost always forget. Today, with Cheikh there, nobody forgot.

We played a little game. Cheikh with Idrissa and Amadou. Me with Moussa and Souleymane.

The first time I got the ball, I tried to dribble past him.

He took it.

Cleanly. Without touching me.

He scored ten seconds later.

“One to nothing,” he said.

I could count.

On the next play, I passed to Moussa. He gave it right back. Cheikh closed the angle. I waited half a heartbeat and slipped the ball between his legs.

The whole field yelled.

I shot.

Amadou saved it.

Cheikh turned toward me.

He wasn't smiling anymore.

"You had Moussa on your left," he said.

"I also had the goal in front of me."

"Not enough of it, apparently."

We played for forty minutes. His team won six to four. Cheikh scored three. I scored two. Moussa scored two.

Afterward, everybody talked about Cheikh's moves. Even Idrissa asked him how he set up his first touch before the ball reached him.

I was getting a drink by the wall when I saw Cheikh pick the ball back up on his own.

He kicked it against the wall, trapped it with his left foot, spun, and shot between two stones.

The shot went wide.

He did it again.

And again.

And again.

On the sixth try, he made it. He didn't smile. He set the ball up for a seventh.

His phone buzzed in his bag.

He rushed over to it.

I was close enough to see only the start of the message:

Coach: squad decision...

Cheikh turned the screen against his palm as soon as he saw me.

"So now you read other people's messages?"

"I was looking at the ball."

"Then look at it."

He shot again.

The ball hit the stone on the right and bounced back to me. I stopped it.

“How long are you going to keep doing that?” I asked.

“Until it’s right.”

“It was right on the sixth shot.”

“For you, maybe.”

That answer stung.

I passed the ball back too hard. He trapped it anyway.

Before he left, he put his cleats away in his bag. A fine red dust had settled on the white.

He rubbed it with his thumb until it was gone.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Challenge

Tuesday, February 20, 2024



Cheikh had promised to come only once.
He came back Monday.

Then again today.

He said he needed to stay sharp during his visit. We acted like it didn't flatter us that an academy player had chosen our field. He acted like our field was just a place that happened to be free.

Everybody was lying a little.

Today, Fatou had set her notebook on a flat rock. She was recording goals and passes because Souleymane was always accusing Amadou of making up the score.

"I don't make it up," Amadou protested. "I forget some of the goals."

"Only the other team's," Fatou said.

We'd been playing for ten minutes when the patched ball took a weird bounce. It jumped up to Cheikh's knee instead

of staying on the ground.

Cheikh controlled it, but Souleymane stole it from him.

“Not bad for a ball that never went to an academy,” he said.

Cheikh won the ball back on the next play and scored.

“With something round, this would be more interesting.”

“You can take yours and go home,” Souleymane said.

“That’s what I do every night.”

He nodded at our ball with his chin.

“You play with garbage, and then you’re surprised nobody takes you seriously.”

Nobody moved.

The word *garbage* stayed there in the middle of the field.

I thought about the cloth Idrissa’s mom had sewn back together. The tape rewrapped so carefully. Moussa’s hands. All the games we’d played with that ball. Cheikh hadn’t insulted an object. He’d insulted all the time we’d put into it.

“That ball beat you twice today,” I said.

“The field beat me. You never know where it’ll bounce.”

“Then go play on your perfect field.”

“Gladly.”

“Or play against us here.”

Moussa took a step toward me.

“Lamine...”

I heard him.

I didn’t listen.

Cheikh crossed his arms.

“We’re already playing.”

“A real game. Your team against ours.”

Some kids who'd been watching crept closer. Two little ones ran off to tell other people, as if we'd just declared war.

Cheikh looked around. He liked an audience. Or he wanted us to think he did.

“Fine. And what are you betting?”

“We don't need to bet anything,” Moussa said.

“Then you've got nothing to lose.”

Cheikh looked down at my shoes.

“Nice laces. We could play for shoes.”

A few people laughed.

Moussa went stiff.

“No,” I said.

“Scared of walking home barefoot?”

“Shoes aren't for betting.”

“Fine. Then the loser admits the other one is the best.”

“The best at what?” Fatou asked.

Cheikh turned to her.

“At soccer.”

“How many players? How long? What ages? Which referee? What field? One game doesn't answer ‘best at soccer.’”

Cheikh looked at her as if a rulebook had started talking.

“Who are you?”

“The one who writes down the score you forget whenever it suits you.”

I heard Moussa smother a laugh.

Cheikh opened his bag and took out his training ball.

“If your team scores against mine, I'll leave you this one.”

Amadou stopped smiling.

The ball wasn't new, but it was solid. Good enough for months of play if we took care of it.

"And if we win?" Souleymane asked.

"You won't win."

"That's not an answer," Fatou said.

Cheikh pressed his lips together.

"If you win, I'll give you a rematch on a neutral field when I come back."

"A rematch?" Idrissa said. "If we win, you're the one who'll need a rematch."

This time everybody laughed, even me.

Cheikh's face shut.

"Next Saturday."

"No way," Moussa said. "Too soon."

"So you're backing out."

"March 9," I said.

I don't know where the date came from. I only knew the wedding would keep the families busy all week and we needed time.

Cheikh did the math.

"I might have to leave before then."

"Scared you won't be around?" Souleymane asked.

"I'll come back on the ninth," Cheikh said. "Even if I have to make the trip."

His phone buzzed. He didn't look at it.

"Six against six, fifty minutes," Fatou went on. "Two halves of twenty-five. Monsieur Diatta as referee, if he agrees. Here only if the field gets approved. If not, we find another place."

"Why is she the one deciding?" Cheikh asked.

“Because you two were betting shoes,” Moussa answered.

Fatou wrote the rules on a page, then read them out loud.



“If Lamine’s team scores at least one goal, it gets the training ball Cheikh brought. If it wins, Cheikh agrees to a new game on a neutral field the next time he visits. No player bets his shoes, his money, his schooling, or his future. Agreed?”

“Why’d you say schooling?” Souleymane asked.

“Because I know you.”

Cheikh held out his hand.

Everybody turned toward me, Lamine the captain.

At least, that’s what I thought for one second.

Then I looked at Moussa.

“Are you in?”

He was surprised I asked.

“If we practice without forgetting everything else.”

I asked Idrissa, Amadou, and Souleymane. Souleymane said yes before I even finished the question. The others agreed.

I shook Cheikh’s hand.

“March 9.”

“March 9.”

He squeezed very hard.

So did I.

After practice, we went to see Monsieur Diatta. He read the page twice.

“I’m not refereeing anything until your families have been told and the field has been inspected,” he said. “And you’ll train with breaks, water, and reasonable hours. This isn’t the national team.”

“Yes, sir,” we answered.

“Who signed the team up for this?”

Everyone looked at me.

“All of us,” I said.

Moussa didn’t add anything.

When I got home, Baba already knew.

News travels faster in Bambali than I do.

He was sitting with Mom. Fatou had come by before me: her page was lying in front of them.

“You gave your word on behalf of a whole team,” Baba said.

“I asked them.”

“After you’d already made the challenge?”

I didn’t answer.

“A promise made in public weighs more,” he went on.

“I know.”

“No. You’re just now finding out how much it weighs.”

Mom pushed the page toward me.

“The market, school, chores, and practice with your father don’t disappear until March 9.”

“I can do it all.”

She looked at me.

I had already said almost the same thing the day the ball split open.

This time, even I didn’t find it very convincing.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What a Week Costs

Thursday, February 22, 2024



I lied to Mom at 3:47.

I lied to Madame Diouf at 4:03.

By 4:20, I was behind the school, and I had managed to believe the two lies canceled each other out.

They didn't cancel each other out.

They had made plans to meet.

It all started with Moussa.

"I can't come tomorrow," he announced at break. "My uncle's getting a delivery."

"Again?"

He looked at me.

The word *again* had just touched the old bruise.

"That's not a dig," I added quickly. "I'm just asking."

"Yes, again."

"Then we'll practice today."

"Your mom needs you on Thursdays."

“Just for an hour.”

“You’ve also got the French assignment.”

Madame Diouf had asked us to work in pairs on a description of a familiar place. I was supposed to work with Fatou after class.

“We’ll finish fast,” I said.

“You just promised not to forget everything else.”

“I’m not forgetting. I’m moving things around.”

That’s how a lie starts: you give it a different name.

At 3:47, I called Mom from the school phone.

“Madame Diouf is keeping us after for the assignment. Fatou and me.”

Silence.

“Until what time?”

“Five thirty.”

“You were supposed to go with Awa and bring the bags to Auntie Coumba’s shop.”

“I’ll do it after.”

“The customer is coming at five.”

I looked at Moussa in the schoolyard. He was bouncing the ball off his knee.

“Fatou needs me,” I said.

The worst part isn’t just that I lied. It’s that I used Fatou, as if she’d asked me for something.

“All right,” Mom answered. “Get your work done.”

At 4:03, Madame Diouf set us up under the classroom awning.

“You can stay until five. Then I’m locking up.”

Fatou opened her notebook.

I wrote two sentences about the field behind the school.

Then I stood up.

“I have to go.”

“Where?” Fatou asked.

“My mom needs me at the market.”

“Right now?”

“Yes.”

Madame Diouf heard.

“You’ll finish tomorrow,” she said. “And bring me the permission slip for the game too.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

At 4:20, I was at the field.

Moussa didn’t say anything, but he didn’t look happy to see me.

“Is it all worked out?”

“Yes.”

“With your mom?”

“Yes.”

Two more lies, free of charge. Once you get started, the next ones cost less. At first, anyway.

We worked on short passes. Cheikh wasn’t there. Fatou wasn’t either. Without her, nobody was counting lost balls. I thought it was a great practice.

We finished at 5:25.

I ran home.

The courtyard was empty.

On the table were six bags of peanuts, two baskets, and Mom’s account book.

The customer had left.

Mom came in a few minutes later with Awa. She wasn’t yelling. I knew right away that I’d have preferred it if

she were.

“Madame Diouf called,” she said.

My whole body went very light, except for my feet.

“She wanted to know if you could stay tomorrow to finish the work you left because of me.”

Awa stared at me with her mouth open.

“Mom...”

“Where were you?”

I could still make something up. Say I’d run into Moussa. That I’d only stayed five minutes. That practice was important.

“At the field.”

Mom set down her bag.

“The customer came all the way from Ziguinchor to put together assortments. She wanted to try my bags in two shops. She couldn’t wait.”

“She can come back.”

The second I said it, I knew it was the wrong thing to say.

“Maybe,” Mom answered. “Maybe not. But you’re not the one who gets to decide whether my chance comes back.”

She opened her book.

“Thirty bags today. If the trial worked, two hundred next month. You didn’t make me lose two hundred bags. You made me lose the chance to find out.”

I stared at the numbers.

In soccer, a missed goal stays visible. Everybody groans. You can replay the moment in your head.

In Mom’s book, the loss was a line that might never exist.

“I’m sorry.”

“You’ll be sorry tomorrow morning too. You’re coming to the market with me before school, and again after. No practice.”

“But the game...”

She closed the book.

“Exactly. You’re going to learn how much time a promise costs when somebody else has to keep it for you.”

Baba came in while I was still searching for an answer.

He understood as soon as he saw our faces.

“What happened?”

Mom told him without adding a single extra word.

Baba asked me:

“You used school to lie to your mother, and your mother to lie to your teacher?”

Put that way, my plan sounded less clever.

“Yes.”

“Give me your journal.”

I looked up.

“Why?”

“You’ll write down what you did.”

“It’s my journal.”

“It’s also a school assignment.”

“Madame Diouf said we get to choose what we share.”

Baba held out his hand, then let it drop.

“Then write. We’ll talk later about what you choose to hide.”

That sentence followed me all the way to my room.

Friday, February 23, 2024

This morning I got up before the sun. At the market, Mom didn't give me a speech. She gave me a list.

Count the bags. Check the knots. Write down the orders. Carry the baskets. Make change while she watched.

I found out that her stall never just waits quietly. One customer asked a price while another wanted change for a bill. A supplier sent a message. Awa wanted water. A tomato that was too ripe had to come out before it spoiled the others.

Mom knew where to put her hands before the problem even showed up.



At one point, a woman asked for twenty bags for a meeting.

Mom figured out the price, offered a pickup the next day, and wrote down the number.

“Why didn’t you just tell her to come back later?” I asked when the woman left.

“Because she might not come back.”

She didn’t stress the words.

She didn’t need to.

After school, Moussa was waiting for me outside the market.

“You’re not coming?”

“No.”

“Does your mom know?”

“She does now.”

He looked down at the baskets.

“You lied?”

“Yes.”

“Because of practice?”

“Because of me.”

That answer tasted bad. That was probably how I knew it was true.

Moussa picked up a basket.

“I can help for ten minutes.”

“What about your uncle?”

“He’s expecting me at five.”

“You’ll be late.”

“No, I won’t. Because I checked the time before I promised.”

He said it without smiling.

I had that coming.

We carried the two baskets to the shop next door. He left on time.

Tonight the team is practicing without me.

Every now and then I hear the ball behind the school.

POC. POC-POC.

The sound comes all the way to the house, slips under the door, and finds me sitting in front of the peanut bags.

I thought a week had a price: being tired, doing drills, maybe blisters on my feet.

I hadn't understood that you could make other people pay it.

PART THREE

Learning to Listen



Chapters 9–13

CHAPTER NINE

The Team Cracks

Saturday, February 24, 2024



This morning I found out you can be the captain of a team that doesn't want to follow you anymore.

It's a pretty useless kind of power.

Mom had said I could join the others once my chores were done. I had counted the bags, delivered two baskets, walked Awa where she needed to go, and recited Abdoulaye's whole branch to Baba without forgetting a single name.

So I got to the field twenty minutes late, very proud of myself, and carrying a complete plan.

The plan was excellent.

On paper, anyway.

I had drawn six circles: Amadou in goal, Idrissa and Souleymane at the back, Moussa and me in the middle, and little Ibrahima up front. He's a year younger than us, but he runs faster than anybody, and we needed a sixth player. I

had added arrows. Lots of arrows. Some of them crossed in a very professional way.

“We’ll start with building out from the back,” I announced.

Souleymane leaned over the page.

“Why am I on defense?”

“Because you’re solid.”

“I’m a striker.”

“Mostly you’re the guy who loses the ball trying to shoot from everywhere.”

“You’re the one saying that?”

Moussa stepped between us.

“Can we try it before we fight about it?”

“He shows up late and brings a treasure map,” Souleymane said.

“It isn’t a map. It’s tactics.”

“Maybe the treasure is the pass you’re finally going to give us.”

Amadou laughed. Even Idrissa ducked his head to hide a smile.

I decided not to answer.

I was in charge.

Captains don’t answer every jab.

They give orders.

“Idrissa, pass to Souleymane. Souleymane, one touch to Moussa. Moussa, you find me between the two stones. We do it ten times.”

“Why the two stones?” Idrissa asked.

“Because that’ll be the space between their midfielders.”

“You know their team?”

"I know Cheikh."

That wasn't the same thing. I realized it the moment I said it, so I said the next part louder.

"Let's go!"

The first try failed because Souleymane's pass was too hard.

The second failed because Moussa had drifted out of the space I'd drawn.

The third failed because I took off before the pass.

I explained their mistakes to them.

On the fourth try, Moussa stopped.

"What about yours?"

"What mistake?"

"You go too early."

"Because your pass comes too late."

"It comes late because you take off before you look."

"If you watched my run..."

"If you watched anything besides yourself..."

The red laces were on my feet. For a second, I felt like they were squeezing tighter.

"Again," I said.

Moussa went back to his spot.

On the sixth try, we got it. The ball moved fast, and I trapped it right between the stones.

"There! Exactly!"

"Now can we play?" Amadou asked.

"Four more times."

Souleymane let his arms drop.

"We get it."

"Getting it once isn't enough."

“You only get things when they’re your idea.”

“If you can’t follow a drill, get off the field.”

The words left my mouth before I decided to say them.

Souleymane waited.

“Get off,” I said again.

This time I’d decided.

He pulled off the strip of cloth he used as an armband and threw it at my feet.

“Sure thing, captain.”

He sat down under the tree.

We played with five.

Well, we tried.

Without Souleymane, Idrissa was all alone at the back. I pushed up to attack, then yelled when Idrissa didn’t cover my spot. Moussa got the ball and looked for an option that didn’t exist anymore. Amadou kept coming out of his goal to help us and leaving it empty.

Three younger boys were watching from the sideline. One of them was Idrissa’s brother, who barely came up to our shoulders.

“Can we play you?” he asked.

“Later,” I said.

“Now,” said Moussa.

“We have to practice.”

“That’s the point.”

The three little ones called over a friend. Souleymane got up to fill out their team.

“You’re playing with them?” I asked.

“They didn’t kick me off.”

We set up two small goals and decided to play for fifteen minutes.

I announced that we had to keep our shape.

Thirty seconds in, I'd forgotten it.

I wanted to win the ball back from Souleymane. Every time he touched it, I left my spot to go after him. He passed to a little kid. The little kid passed to another one. They weren't better than us. They just played simpler.

In the fourth minute, they scored.

In the seventh, I tied it up after dribbling past two players.

I yelled:

"See?"

Nobody answered.

In the tenth minute, I tried the same dribble. I lost the ball. Souleymane sent Idrissa's brother through, and he scored between Amadou's legs.

Two to one.

In the fourteenth minute, Moussa was wide open on the left.

I shot.

Wide.

The little kids won.

Idrissa's brother ran around the field with his arms spread out. Souleymane lifted him up in the air. I wanted to disappear and, at the same time, explain to everyone that this game didn't count.

Fatou was standing by the tree.

I hadn't seen her come.

She had her notebook.

Of course.

“How long have you been watching?”

“Since you started the drill for the sixth time.”

“Did you write down the score?”

“Yes.”

“Everybody knows the score.”

“I didn’t write down only the score.”

She showed me a page. Lines made columns with our initials at the top. Next to my L, there were way too many marks.

“What’s that?”

“Lost balls.”

“You didn’t see everything.”

“Maybe I missed one or two.”

“What about my successful dribbles?”

“Four.”

“Shots?”

“Five. One on target.”

“I scored.”

“Yes. On your only shot on target.”

She didn’t say it meanly. That was worse. She said it as if numbers didn’t need to get angry.

“How many balls did Moussa lose?”

“Two.”

“Because he never tries anything.”

Moussa looked at me.

I regretted it instantly.

“I didn’t mean...”

“Yes, you did,” he said. “You meant exactly that.”

He picked up his bag.

“Wait. We need to talk about the next practice.”

“You can talk to your paper.”

Idrissa left with his brother. Amadou followed them. Souleymane didn’t even glance my way.

Fatou closed her notebook.

“Did you want a team or proof that you’re the best?”

“I want to win.”

“That wasn’t my question.”

She left too.

I stayed there alone with my arrows.

The wind lifted my page. It tumbled over to one of the goals, got stuck against a stone, and kept fluttering there as if it still wanted to give orders.

CHAPTER TEN

The River Doesn't Hurry

Sunday, February 25, 2024



Baba took me down to the river without saying why. I figured Mom had told him about practice. Or Moussa had told somebody who told somebody who told Baba.

In Bambali, secrets often have more legs than kids do.

We left after breakfast. The sun wasn't heavy yet. Baba carried a water bottle and an old bag. I carried nothing.

"Are we going to the river?" I asked.

"You just said it. The river."

"Why?"

"To get there."

I got ready for a long morning of mysterious sentences.

The path went in and out of shade. A motorbike passed us. Farther on, a man was mending a net. We could hear voices near the canoes and the steady knock of a tool against wood.

Baba still wasn't talking.

I hate grownup silence when I know there's already a conversation inside it.

"If this is about yesterday, Souleymane wasn't listening to anything."

Baba kept walking.

"And Moussa kept arguing with me."

Still nothing.

"And the little kids won because there were only five of us."

"How many of them were there?" Baba asked.

"Five."

"So you were even."

I would have preferred it if he'd stayed quiet.

We stopped at a spot where the bank sloped down gently. The water moved along without seeming to be in any hurry. Baba put down his bag and sat.

I stayed standing.

"Are you going to tell me about the river?"

"What do you want to know?"

"Nothing."

"Then I have nothing to say."

He opened the bottle and drank.

I waited.

One minute.

Two.

Maybe five.

Without a ball, a page of plans, or anybody to boss around, time moved way too slowly.

A blue and orange bird landed on a low branch over the water.

“Is that a kingfisher?” I asked.

“Yes.”

“What’s it doing?”

“Watch.”

The bird wasn’t doing anything.

Well, it was probably doing something, but from the outside it mostly looked like a bird that had forgotten why it came.

Then it dove.

A blue arrow.

It came back up almost at once, without a fish, and landed a little farther along.

“It missed,” I said.

Baba didn’t answer.

The bird held perfectly still. It tilted its head to one side, then the other. A canoe went by in the distance. Little ripples reached the bank.

The kingfisher waited.

I thought it was going to fly off.

It dove again.

This time something silver flashed in its beak.



“It knew where to look,” I whispered.

“Maybe.”

“The first time, it went too fast.”

“Maybe.”

“You could say something besides ‘maybe.’”

“You could also keep going without me.”

I picked up a little piece of wood and tossed it into the water.

“Fatou counted my lost balls.”

“How many?”

“A lot.”

“Is that a new number?”

“Nine.”

“And the others?”

“Fewer.”

“Do you think she lied?”

“No.”

The piece of wood was turning in circles near the bank.

“I wanted them to do what I’d planned. It was a good plan.”

“A plan can be good and still not fit the people who have to play it.”

“Then what’s the captain for?”

Baba rubbed his hands together. He does that before he plays.

“I ask myself that a lot, with you.”

I thought he was making fun of me. His face was serious.

“I want to pass on to you what I know,” he went on. “When you refuse, I talk louder. When you pull away, I give you more work. And the tighter I hold on, the less you hear.”

I had never heard Baba admit he could do something wrong.

I didn’t know what to say.

“Are you going to stop the lessons?”

“I didn’t say that.”

Of course not.

“I’m trying to understand how to help you without deciding for you.”

“You could start by not deciding for me.”

Baba turned his head toward me.

Maybe I’d said that too fast.

Then he smiled.

Not for long. Just long enough for me to see it.

“And you could start by saying what you’re really afraid of.”

The smile was gone.

I stared at the water.

“Cheikh plays better than me.”

The words left a big empty space behind them.

“Today?” Baba asked.

“I don’t know. He trains at an academy. He has coaches, a real field, real games. When he controls the ball, everything looks easy.”

“And what does that make you?”

“Somebody who plays behind his school.”

“That’s a place, not a person.”

“Somebody ordinary, then.”

There it was.

That was what I hadn’t said to Moussa, or Fatou, or even to my journal. If Cheikh was better, then maybe my dream didn’t prove anything. Maybe I was just one boy among lots of others, with shoes too big for me and a ball that changes direction on its own.

Baba didn’t say I was exceptional.

I think part of me was hoping he would.

“You’re afraid of being ordinary,” he said.

“Yes.”

“So am I, sometimes.”

I looked at him.

“You?”

“Do you think the names always come when I call them?”

I thought about Bakary.

“No,” I said.

“That day, you heard what was missing.”

“Because you stopped.”

“Exactly.”

The kingfisher flew off low over the water.

On the way home, Baba didn't hand me a single solution. He didn't explain how to beat Cheikh or how to get the team back.

He only asked me:

"What didn't you see yesterday?"

I thought about the nine lost balls. About Moussa wide open on the left. About Souleymane sitting under the tree. About the little kids passing the ball before I could jump on them.

"A lot of things."

At home, I found Moussa by the gate. He had come to pick up a book his little sister had lent Awa.

I almost told him about the kingfisher.

It would have sounded like one more lesson I wanted to force on him.

So instead I asked:

"What do you see in our game that I don't?"

Moussa studied me for a long time.

"You really want to know?"

I looked at his feet. Then at his face.

"Yes."

"Then we're going to need more than five minutes."

We sat down in front of the house.

For once, I didn't go first.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Page Nobody Reads

Tuesday, February 27, 2024



Baba opened my journal today.
I found him sitting under the awning with the notebook on his knees.

Open.

To the page about the lie.

For a second, I didn't understand what I was looking at. Maybe the notebook was his. Some other notebook with the same black cover and the same worn corners.

Then I recognized my sentence at the top of the page:

I LIED TO MOM AT 3:47.

“What are you doing?”

My voice cracked across the courtyard like a whip.

Baba looked up.

He didn't close the notebook right away.

That's the detail I'll remember longest.

“I was looking for your French assignment,” he said.

“In my journal?”

“Madame Diouf asked for a description.”

“It’s in my class notebook.”

“I couldn’t find it.”

“Then you ask.”

He finally closed the journal.

I went over and took it out of his hands.

“How much did you read?”

“Lamine...”

“How much?”

“The page was open.”

“No. The notebook was shut inside my bag.”

His eyes moved to the bag lying by the mat.

He knew that I knew.

Mom appeared in the doorway. Awa was behind her.

“What’s going on?”

“He read my journal.”

Baba stood up.

“I was checking on the assignment he didn’t finish after he lied.”

“That’s not an answer,” I said.

“Don’t talk to me in that tone.”

“Don’t read my journal!”

The silence slammed into the whole courtyard.

Awa took a step back.

I had never yelled at Baba like that.

My heart was pounding all the way into my hands. I was scared, and I was still too angry to hide it.

“Go to your room,” Baba said.

“With my notebook.”

“Lamine.”

“It’s mine.”

Mom moved over near the table. Not between us, but close enough that we both felt she was there.

“Boubacar,” she said. “Did he give you permission?”

Baba didn’t look at her.

“I’m his father.”

“That still isn’t the question.”

Yaye Khady, who was sorting leaves at the back of the courtyard, hadn’t moved. She only murmured:

“A door is still a door, even inside your own house.”

Baba took a slow breath.

I held the journal against my chest. I wanted to leave. I also wanted to stay until he said exactly what I was waiting for.



He looked at me.

"No," he said. "You didn't give me permission."

Nobody spoke.

"I was looking for the assignment. I saw the first sentence, and I kept reading."

He paused.

"I shouldn't have."

I waited for the *but*.

But you lied.

But I'm your father.

But this notebook is also homework.

The *but* never came.

"I'm sorry," he said.

I didn't answer.

An apology doesn't fix everything. Moussa taught me that with the red laces.

"What did you read?" I asked.

"The beginning of that page. And a few lines about the market."

"Nothing else?"

"Nothing else."

I didn't know if I believed him all the way. That thought hurt even more than the reading did.

"I'm keeping the journal with me," I said.

"All right."

"And nobody opens it."

"All right."

I went to my room.

I slid the notebook under my mat. Then I took it back out. Then I put it in my bag. No hiding place seemed safe enough, because the place wasn't the problem anymore.

The problem was that Baba now knew that at 3:47 I had chosen the field over Mom.

He knew about my shame without my giving it to him.

After dinner, he knocked softly on the doorframe.

"May I come in?"

He had never asked that before.

"Yes."

He stayed standing.

"We need to plan out the days before the game."

"Not now."

"All right."

He started to leave.

"Baba."

He stopped.

"What did you think you'd find in my journal?"

"Proof that you were working."

"And you found proof that I'd lied."

"Yes."

"Were you happy?"

"No."

He sat down by the door, not on my bed.

"I was worried. I should have asked how your work was going. I checked for myself instead."

That didn't sound like a perfect apology. It sounded like something hard to say.

"After the game," I told him, "maybe I'll read you a page."

"The one you choose."

"Yes."

"And if you don't want to?"

I hadn't expected that question.

"Then I won't read you anything."

Baba nodded.

"All right."

We talked about the schedule. Not for long. Thirty minutes of storytelling on Mondays and Wednesdays. Practice the other evenings, after homework and the chores we'd planned. If a time has to change, I ask. I don't move things around by myself.

"This is temporary," Baba said.

"Everything's temporary with you."

"You too. You keep growing without permission."

I almost laughed.

Almost.

When he left, I opened the journal to the first page.

I wanted to tear out today's page before I'd even written it.

I didn't.

If I start pulling out every page somebody might misuse, it won't be my journal anymore. It'll just be a notebook that's scared.

So I'm writing it all down.

But nobody reads this page.

Not yet.

CHAPTER TWELVE

A Field for Everyone

Saturday, March 2, 2024



We found three pieces of glass, twelve sharp stones, a piece of wire, and a hole deep enough to swallow Awa's ankle.

The hole had been there a long time.

We kept running past without looking at how deep it was. Awa had stopped to look.

"I found something!" she shouted.

"Don't touch it!" I shouted back.

She froze, her hand a few inches from the rusty wire.

Monsieur Diatta came over with gloves on and pulled it out. He dropped it into a bucket with the pieces of glass.

"This is why you inspect before you play," he said.

On the day of the challenge, when he'd talked about checking the field, I thought he was exaggerating. We played here almost every day. If the field were dangerous, we would know.

Apparently, danger doesn't fill out a form before it shows up.

There were about twenty of us this morning: the players, Fatou, Awa, a few parents, Monsieur Diatta, and two older boys from the neighborhood. Baba had brought tools. Mom brought a cooler of water and some cups. Even Yaye Khady came, mostly to give advice to people who hadn't asked for any.

Cheikh stood with Malang at the edge of the field.

Malang had agreed to provide two bags of sand and a wheelbarrow. He was talking with Monsieur Diatta about the patch that needed filling in.

Cheikh was looking at our main hole.

"That one helps you," he said.

"How can a hole help us?" Amadou asked.

"You know where it is. We don't."

Souleymane stopped picking up stones.

"He's not wrong."

Fatou looked up from her list.

"You want to win because somebody twists his ankle?"

"I didn't say that. We could leave a few bumps. We've always played on them."

"Bumps, sure," said Idrissa. "Not the hole."

Souleymane nudged a stone with his foot.

"Cheikh plays on flat fields. Here at least we know how the ball bounces."

Everybody's eyes came to me.

Since the challenge, that had been happening a lot. At first, I liked it. Now every look felt like a question I had to answer correctly before anyone else.

I looked at the hole.

I knew that spot. We could steer Cheikh over to that side. Not so he'd get hurt. Just to slow him down. Just so the field would be part of the game.

Just is a very useful word when you want to make a bad idea smaller.

Awa was still staring at the bucket where Monsieur Diatta had tossed the wire.

I remembered Fatou's page. Nine lost balls. Facts that didn't change just because they bothered me.

"We fill the hole," I said.



Souleymane sighed.

"And the bumps?"

"We take out whatever can hurt somebody. We're not going to turn the field into a living room."

"Too bad," said Yaye Khady. "I brought cushions."

Even Monsieur Diatta laughed.

We worked all morning. The older boys filled the main hole. We moved the stones, pulled out the little pieces of metal, and marked off a damp patch where nobody was supposed to go. The youngest kids only picked up trash that couldn't hurt them, while the grownups kept an eye on them.

Fatou checked off each area on a drawing of the field.

"You made a plan?" I asked her.

"Yes."

"With arrows?"

"No. Holes don't move when you yell at them."

I had that coming too.

Around noon, Malang helped Baba push the wheelbarrow. Cheikh got a message. He walked off to answer it.

I didn't mean to listen.

I really was stacking stones near him.

"Yes, coach... Yes... I'm heading back Monday... No, I haven't lost my rhythm."

He lowered his voice.

"Have you decided on the squad?"

Silence.

"Okay."

When he turned around, his face was shut tight.

"You're leaving Monday?" I asked.

"For the academy."

"And you're coming back for the game?"

"I said I would."

"What did your coach decide?"

"That's none of your business."

He kicked a little stone. It rolled all the way to the bucket.

“If they sent you back here, would that be so terrible?” I asked.

Cheikh spun around so fast I stepped back.

“They’re not sending me back.”

“I didn’t say...”

“You think I do all this so I can come back and play behind the school?”

His voice had carried. Several people were looking at us.

He realized it and lowered his voice.

“I’ll be back on the ninth. Get your team ready.”

He walked off toward Malang.

I stayed there with the stone he’d kicked.

That’s what surprised me most about Cheikh: when he was far away, he talked about the village like a place he loved, and when he was here, he talked about it like a loss that might happen to him.

In the afternoon, we tested the field with a light scrimmage. Monsieur Diatta checked the boundaries. He pointed out the spots that were still off limits and said he’d come back the day before the game.

The ball rolled better.

Not perfectly. Well enough.

At one point, Moussa called over to me:

“Do you miss the hole?”

“A little.”

“Me too.”

“Really?”

“No. I just wanted to see if you’d lie.”

I kicked the ball to him.

He let it roll between his legs to Awa, who was running behind us.

She kicked it as hard as she could.

The ball went two meters.

Everybody clapped anyway.

The field wasn't ours because we'd been playing on it for a long time.

Today, for the first time, I thought it could be ours because we took care of it.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Three Things I Can Hold On To

Friday, March 8, 2024



The game is tomorrow.
I tried to write about something else for ten minutes.

Here's what I wrote:

The sky was clear today.

Then:

We had rice for lunch.

Then:

Awa spilled tea on her notebook and claims the stain looks like Africa.

All of that is true.

None of it is the game.

This morning, Cheikh came back from the academy. I saw him near the Fatys' house with a bag on his shoulder. He didn't come by the field. Souleymane says it's a strategy to scare us.

Mostly I think the trip wore him out.

Maybe I'm starting to see things without turning them straight into insults.

Or maybe I'm trying to sound wise in my journal.

After school, Monsieur Diatta ran our last session. Twenty-five minutes, that's all.

"No full game," he announced. "Warm up, passing, set pieces, cool down. Drink before you get thirsty."

Souleymane muttered:

"Even my mom gives fewer orders."

"Your mom never tried to stop you from shooting from midfield," I said.

He smiled.

It was the first time since Saturday.

We went back over a way of building out from the back, close to the one on my page. This time, I didn't put everybody in position before we started.

"Idrissa, where do you like to get the ball?"

He showed me.

"Souleymane, if Moussa drops back, what do you do?"

"I take the space up front."

"And if Cheikh follows you?"

"Then somebody else is open."

He looked at me.

"See, I can think even though I'm a striker."

“I’m taking notes.”

Fatou, on the sideline, actually did.

We got the play right four times out of six. Not ten. Monsieur Diatta stopped us before I could ask to run it again.

“Save the hunger for tomorrow.”

After the session, we stayed in the shade to talk about the lineup. Not for long. Amadou had brought a water bottle for everybody. Idrissa was checking laces. Souleymane was telling us he’d score three goals, but nobody was really listening.

Moussa sat down next to me.

“Are you scared?”

“No.”

He waited.

“Yes,” I said.

“Me too.”

“Of losing?”

“Of playing badly in front of everybody. Of missing an easy trap. Of passing you the ball and watching you try to dribble past six people.”

“There’ll only be six players on their side.”

“See? You’re already counting.”

We laughed.

He gave one of my red laces a little tug.

“Are they holding?”

“Yes.”

“Maybe we are too.”

“You just said a Baba sentence.”

“Never repeat that.”

In the evening, I went to the mosque with Baba. After prayers, the conversations were already about Ramadan coming up. At home, Mom had started checking the supplies and planning the days of the next week. The grownups were talking about schedules, meals, and what the younger kids would do depending on their age and strength.

Awa announced that she would fast “at least until breakfast.”

Yaye Khady told her that such a sacrifice would surely impress the whole neighborhood.

I was thinking about the game.

After dinner, Baba took out his drum. We hadn’t done Wednesday’s session because of the market. He played a short pattern.

DOUM. DOUM-DOUM. PA.

I copied it with my fingers on my knee.

“Again,” he said.

I did it again.

“You speed up at the end.”

“I know.”

“Then why?”

“Because I want to get there.”

“Where?”

I looked up.

He was smiling a little.

“You talk like that on purpose.”

“Sometimes.”

He played it again. This time, I waited between the second and third beats. The silence was small, but it was

part of the rhythm.

“Baba, do you think we’ll win?”

His hands came to rest on the drumhead.

Maybe I was expecting: Yes, if your heart is strong. Or: *The ancestors will be with you.* Some beautiful sentence I could write down here and repeat to myself tomorrow.

“I don’t know,” he said.

“That’s it?”

“Would you rather have a lie told well?”

“No.”

“I know you’ve worked hard. I know Cheikh plays well. I know a ball sometimes changes direction without asking anyone’s permission.”

“Especially our patched ball.”

“Especially that one.”

He covered the drum.

“You can’t hold on to the result before it exists.”

“Then what can I hold on to?”

“That’s not for me to choose.”

Again.

Grownups go very quiet exactly when their answers might actually be useful.



I came in here to write.

I thought about the first practice, my nine lost balls, the kingfisher, the journal Baba closed, the hole we filled, and Moussa's question.

I can't promise we'll win.

I can promise three things:

- 1 *Listen. Not just for my own name. Watch the runs, the spaces, and the faces.*
- 2 *Pass. When somebody's in a better spot, even if everybody's waiting for me to shoot.*
- 3 *Play fair. If Cheikh taunts us, if they score on us, if we lose.*

I'm reading the third one again.

It's probably the hardest.

My shoes are by the bed. The red laces are clean. Mom checked that I've got water ready. Awa wants to carry the ball tomorrow, but we haven't promised her anything yet, because she might sleep with it.

Outside, somebody is tapping a ball softly.

POC.

Then silence.

POC-POC.

I don't know who's playing at this hour.

I close my eyes.

For the first time, I'm not trying to guess where the next sound should go.

I'm waiting for it to come.

PART FOUR

Two Rhythms



Chapters 14–17

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The First Goal

Saturday, March 9, 2024



I have to write the game down in order.

If I start with the ending, I'll change everything else. My mistakes will turn into very clever fakes. My scared moments will turn into calm. And every time I got lucky, I'll explain that I planned it all along.

I didn't plan it all.

At 2:20, mostly what I'd planned was to throw up behind the school.

"Are you sick?" Awa asked.

"No."

"You have that face."

"What face?"

She puffed out her cheeks and made her eyes huge.

"I do not have that face."

"Yes, you do."

Mom put her in charge of the crate of water bottles so she'd stop staring at me. It didn't work. Awa looked at me between every bottle.

The field didn't look quite like ours anymore. Monsieur Diatta had marked the lines with white powder. Two real small goals had been lent to us for the day. A rope kept the spectators back. Near the tree, Mom had set out the water, cups, and a little first aid kit.

Fatou was holding three things: her notebook, a pen, and a watch she'd borrowed from her father.

"Are you playing or taking a test?" I asked her.

"I'm making sure you don't turn fifty minutes into a legend three hours long."

"I never exaggerate."

She wrote something down.

"What?"

"First exaggeration, 2:26."

Moussa showed up with Idrissa. Souleymane was right behind them with the patched ball under his arm. We had decided to warm up with the old one and keep the match ball, which Monsieur Diatta was lending us, safe in his bag.

Amadou was already checking the goals.

"The left one is smaller," he announced.

"They're the same size," Idrissa said.

"From far away, sure."

"You'll be in both of them, one each half."

Amadou measured with his feet. He got nine steps on one side and eight and a half on the other, because his last step landed in the middle of a stone.

He asked to measure again.

Nobody listened to him.

At 2:37, Cheikh arrived with his team.

No parade. No music. One van and two motorbikes. The boys came from the academy or from neighboring villages. Their jerseys were all the same color without being exactly alike. Cheikh had his white cleats on, less white than on the first day. The red dust had won a few spots.

Malang walked behind them.

Cheikh greeted me with a jerk of his chin.

“Is the field flat now?”

“Flat enough that you can’t blame it.”

He looked at the hole we had filled.

“We’ll see.”

Promise number three: play fair.

I didn’t say anything else.

We gave our lineups to Monsieur Diatta.

For us: Amadou in goal; Idrissa at the back; Moussa and me in the middle; Souleymane up front; little Ibrahima free to roam down the wing.

“I’m not little,” Ibrahima protested.

“It’s your player name,” Souleymane said. “Little Ibrahima. When you get bigger, we’ll call you Big Little Ibrahima.”

Ibrahima bumped him with his shoulder.

Cheikh’s team had Fadel in goal, Malick and Demba at the back, then Cheikh, Pathé, and Saliou.

Monsieur Diatta went over the rules: two halves of twenty-five minutes, five minutes of rest in between, substitutions allowed, no dangerous tackles, play stops immedi-

ately if a player gets hurt. He checked the lines one last time and asked if everyone had had something to drink.

“The game ends when I blow the whistle,” he finished. “Not when you think you’ve won.”

He was looking mostly at Souleymane.

At 2:55, we warmed up.

I could feel every part of my body separately. My laces around my feet. The cloth of my jersey on my shoulders. The dust in my throat. My heart was pounding way too fast for someone who hadn’t done anything yet.

Baba was standing next to Mom. He hadn’t brought his drum.

Part of me was disappointed.

Another part was relieved. I didn’t want everyone turning the game into a battle between his rhythm and my ball.

Baba pressed two fingers against his chest.

Then he raised them toward me.

I didn’t know exactly what the gesture meant.

I kept it anyway.

At three o’clock, Monsieur Diatta blew the whistle.

Cheikh touched the ball first.

For the first minute, nobody did anything special. We ran too fast. So did they. The ball went out, came back, switched feet.

In the third minute, I intercepted a pass and saw Moussa take off down the left.

I saw him.

I’m saying that because it matters.

I saw him, and then I decided I could squeeze between Malick and Demba.

I got past Malick.

Demba took the ball off me.

“Pass sooner!” Moussa shouted.

“I almost made it!”

He threw his arms wide.

Promise number one: listen.

Already, I was pretending to listen.

In the sixth minute, Moussa gave me the ball in the middle. Souleymane was calling for it up front. Ibrahima was open on the right. I thought about the crowd, about Cheikh, about my laces, about the shot everybody would talk about.

I held the ball one touch too long.

Pathé stole it.

Cheikh took off.

He didn’t look like he was running any faster than we were. But space kept opening up in front of him. He froze Idrissa, passed to Saliou, got the ball back behind us, and shot.

Amadou dove.

Wide.

The shot grazed the post.

Cheikh turned toward me.

He didn’t say anything.

His silence said plenty.

In the ninth minute, I tried again to win the ball too far up the field. Malick played it behind me. Pathé found Cheikh between Idrissa and me.

This time Cheikh didn’t blast it.

He waited for Amadou to move and placed the ball on the other side.

ZERO TO ONE.

The boys on his team ran to him. Cheikh pumped his fists. On the sideline, a lot of people were shouting his name.

People were shouting ours too, but his was the only one I could hear.

The ball was already back at the center spot when Moussa came over to me.

“Look at me.”

I was looking at Cheikh.

“Lamine. Look at me.”

I turned my head.

“There are forty minutes left,” he said.

“I know.”

“No, you don’t. You’re running like there are two.”

Monsieur Diatta whistled for the restart.

In the twelfth minute, Souleymane lost the ball near their goal. Cheikh picked it up and crossed the whole field. He got past Ibrahima, then Moussa. Idrissa backed up to close the angle.

I was behind the play.

I wasn’t going to get back in time.

Cheikh hit a low shot.

Amadou stuck out his leg.

The ball hit his foot and rolled out of bounds.

Everybody screamed.

Amadou got up with his eyes enormous.

“Did you see that?” he yelled.

“Yes!”

“The left goal really is smaller!”

Even Monsieur Diatta smiled.

The laughing opened something up in my chest. Not enough to get rid of the fear. Enough to remind me there were six of us.

In the sixteenth minute, I got a pass from Idrissa.

I heard Souleymane call.

Then Moussa.

Then Ibrahima.

Three voices.

Before, I would have picked the one that led fastest to the goal.

This time, I lifted my head.

Ibrahima was open. I passed him the ball. He moved forward, pulled Malick out of position, and gave it to Moussa. Moussa switched it over to Souleymane.

We didn’t score. Souleymane shot over the bar.

But Cheikh stopped smiling.

Fatou tapped her notebook twice.

I didn’t know what she’d written.

I only knew that for the first time, we’d made their whole team move.

In the eighteenth minute, the ball went out of bounds near her.

I went to get it.

Fatou handed it to me.

“Three passes before the shot,” she said.

“Is that good?”

“It’s new.”

Monsieur Diatta was hurrying us to restart.

Moussa came up beside me.

He said only one word:

“Listen.”

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Red Pass

Saturday, March 9, 2024



In the nineteenth minute, I started to hear the game differently.

Not as one huge noise.

As lots of small, separate sounds.

Idrissa's breathing when he pushed forward. Moussa's two claps before he made a run. Souleymane shouting my name even when he wasn't open. Cheikh's footsteps behind me. Monsieur Diatta's voice calling a throw-in.

And under all of it, the kicks against the ball.

POC. POC-POC.

Call.

Answer.

I didn't think about Baba. Not in words. But my feet stopped running before my eyes did.

In the twenty-first minute, I let a ball run past me to Moussa. He found Souleymane, who laid it back too hard. Fadel came out and grabbed it.

“Again!” Moussa shouted.

Not sorry. Not *you should have*.

Again.

In the twenty-third minute, Idrissa won a battle against Pathé and passed the ball to me. Cheikh planted himself in front of me. Malick was coming in on my right.

Moussa started a run on the left.

I could see him without looking straight at him. Two slow steps, then a burst.

Cheikh stuck out his foot.

I pulled the ball back toward me. Malick closed in. Two players around me.

Exactly what I would have wanted a week earlier: two opponents, a crowd, and a chance to prove I could get between them.

My red laces flashed across my eyes.

Not like a sign.

Like Moussa’s hand by the wall, the night he said this didn’t fix everything.

I waited one beat.

Then I pushed the ball between Cheikh and Malick.



Not toward the goal.

Toward Moussa.

He took it in stride.

Fadel came out.

Moussa hit it with his right foot, no extra power, just
past Fadel's leg.

The ball rolled.

One second.

Two.

It hit the inside of the post and crossed the line.

ONE TO ONE.

I don't remember who screamed first. Maybe me. Maybe
Awa. Maybe the whole field.

Moussa ran at me.

I thought he was going to jump into my arms.

He punched my shoulder.

“You took long enough!”

I shoved him.

“You could’ve run faster!”

Souleymane piled on top of us. Ibrahima too. Even Idrissa had left his half of the field.

On the sideline, Awa was shouting:

“The ball is ours! The ball is ours!”

She had understood the rule before several of the grownups.

We had scored.

Even if the game ended right then, Cheikh had to give us his training ball.

When I got up, he was standing near the center of the field.

His face didn’t show anything.

“It’s only one goal,” he said.

“That was the rule,” Fatou answered from the sideline.

“The game’s not over.”

“Neither is the rule.”

Monsieur Diatta called everybody back.

There was less than a minute to go before halftime.

Cheikh immediately tried to go all the way on his own. Idrissa slowed him down. I closed the angle and Moussa won the ball. We didn’t attack. We kept possession until the whistle.

At halftime, we sat in the shade.

Mom handed out water. She didn’t talk about the goal. She watched each of us drink.

Baba stayed behind the rope.

Fatou crouched down in front of us with her notebook.

“At the start: four lost balls in nine minutes. Since then: one.”

She was looking at me.

“I know.”

“No. Now you know.”

“Is there a difference?”

“Don’t start again,” Moussa said. “We have five minutes.”

Fatou showed us a little map of the field.

“They close in on Lamine when he gets the ball. That leaves Moussa or Ibrahima open. Cheikh tracks back less when the play goes to the other side.”

“He’s saving his energy,” Idrissa said.

“Or he wants the next goal,” I answered.

Souleymane was wiping his face.

“What about me?”

“You keep both their defenders busy,” Fatou said.

“So I do the work and Moussa scores.”

“Yes.”

He thought about it.

“I don’t like these tactics.”

“They work,” Moussa said.

“That’s why I hate them a little less.”

Monsieur Diatta called the teams back.

Before we started again, Cheikh walked past me.

“You won’t make that same pass twice.”

“Then I’ll make a different one.”

I’m pretty proud of that answer.

I only thought of it after he'd already walked past, but he heard it anyway.

The second half started slower. Our legs were heavy. It had gotten hotter. We didn't run for nothing anymore.

In the thirtieth minute, Cheikh set up Pathé in front of the goal. Amadou came out just in time and smothered the ball with both hands. He stayed on the ground for a second with the ball against his chest.

Monsieur Diatta came over.

"Are you okay?"

Amadou said yes and got up without wincing. Play started again only after he'd been checked.

In the thirty-fourth minute, Souleymane got the ball with his back to the goal. Malick was all over him. He could have tried to turn. I saw him hesitate.

"Hold it!" I shouted.

He laid it back to Moussa, then ran through the middle. Malick followed him. A space opened on the right for Ibrahima.

We still didn't score. Ibrahima's cross went past everybody.

But Souleymane stuck his thumb up.

He had just gone along with a play where his best move was not touching the ball a second time.

I think that cost him a lot.

In the thirty-seventh minute, I had a real chance. Moussa found me at the edge of the box. The goal was right in front of me. Fadel was a little to the left.

I shot.

The ball sailed over.

I waited for the sting of the mistake, the need to kick the dirt or blame the bounce.

It came.

Then it left, faster than usual.

“Get back in position!” Idrissa shouted.

I got back in position.

In the fortieth minute, the score was still one to one.

We had already won the promised ball.

But nobody on our team was playing to stop there.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Last Beat

Saturday, March 9, 2024



In the forty-first minute, Cheikh almost scored.

He got the ball near the line, burst past Ibrahima, and cut toward the middle. I was too far away. Moussa went with him, but Pathé blocked his path.

Cheikh wound up for the shot.

Idrissa stepped in front of him.

Not turning his back. Not throwing himself any which way.

Standing tall and solid, arms close to his body.

The ball hit his shin and went out.

Idrissa took a step back.

Monsieur Diatta asked if he could keep going. He moved his leg, put his foot down, and said yes.

“Great block,” I told him.

“I also accept goals,” he answered.

Cheikh took the corner kick. Amadou punched it away with both fists. The ball came down toward me.

I wanted to go on my own.

Malick cut me off. I passed to Moussa.

Promise number two.

By the forty-third minute, both teams were breathing hard. Monsieur Diatta called a short water break when the ball went out. Nobody complained.

Baba was still standing in the same spot.

This time, his fingers were tapping softly against his forearm.

DOUM. DOUM-DOUM. PA.

I couldn't hear it from that far away.

I knew the movement.

When play started again, Cheikh dropped deeper to get the ball. He wanted to touch every play. I recognized that way of playing.

I had carried it around for weeks.

He passed, called for it right back, ran at the goal, and blamed the others for being a second late.

In the forty-fifth minute, he tried a long shot. Amadou caught it on the second try.

"Five minutes left!" Fatou announced.

The crowd yelled louder.

The noise got huge again.

I remembered the kingfisher.

Not the beautiful bird of my memories. The real one: the one that dove, missed, waited, and tried again.

In the forty-seventh minute, Malick passed to Cheikh in the middle.

I was close enough to go for the ball.

My body wanted to go.

I waited.

One beat.

Cheikh pushed the ball out in front of himself to speed up.

That's when I stepped in.

My foot touched the ball, not his ankle. The ball squirted over to Moussa.

"Now!" I shouted.

Moussa trapped it and looked up.

Souleymane made a run through the middle. Malick went with him. Demba couldn't decide between him and me.

The field opened up.

Moussa gave the ball back to me in one touch.

I had it facing the goal.

Fadel was coming out.

Cheikh was racing back behind me.

Everybody was waiting for me to shoot.

So was I.

Then, at the far post, I saw Idrissa.

Our defender.

The one who had just blocked Cheikh.

He had kept running without calling for the ball. Nobody was marking him, because nobody thought Idrissa would be there.

I slid the ball across the front of the goal.

Hard enough to get past Fadel.
Not hard enough to go out.
Idrissa got there.
He hit it with the inside of his foot.
The net moved.



For one second, the whole field went silent.
As if it had to check twice.
Then the noise crashed down on us.

TWO TO ONE.

Idrissa didn't run.
He stayed in front of the goal with his hands on his head,
like someone who had just found out he had feet.
Souleymane knocked him over hugging him. Moussa
grabbed me by the jersey. Ibrahima was screaming without
making any actual words.

I looked for Cheikh.

He was standing in the middle of the field.

He was staring at the goal.

Monsieur Diatta pulled us apart.

“Two minutes left! Back in position!”

Two minutes can be very long when you’re ahead.

Cheikh attacked straight from the restart. He got past one player, then two. Idrissa backed up. I came back to close him down with Moussa. Cheikh passed to Saliou, who crossed.

Amadou caught it.

He lay down on the ball.

“Get up!” Cheikh shouted.

“He’s playing,” Monsieur Diatta answered. “Back off.”

Amadou got up without hurrying, but without wasting time on purpose either. He rolled it to Idrissa. Idrissa to Moussa. Moussa to Ibrahima. We kept the ball moving.

Cheikh was chasing the ball.

I knew that feeling too.

In the fiftieth minute, the ball went out on the side.

Monsieur Diatta looked at his watch.

He blew the whistle once.

A second time.

One last, longer blast. It was over.

I didn’t fall to my knees.

I didn’t throw my arms up at the sky.

I looked at Moussa.

He looked at my laces.

Then we laughed.

All around us, everybody was running onto the field. Awa got there first and slammed into my stomach. Mom came after her, telling her to let me breathe. Yaye Khady kept saying she had predicted the win, which isn't true. She had predicted three different scores since that morning.

Baba waited for the others to clear out.

"Two to one," I said.

"I can count."

"Idrissa scored."

"I saw."

I wanted him to say something big.

He put his hand on my shoulder.

"You heard."

It was enough.

Farther off, Cheikh was packing up his things.

The promised ball was still in his bag.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

What Cheikh Leaves Behind

Sunday, March 10, 2024



Cheikh wanted to leave without giving us the ball. I don't know if he really meant to keep it. Maybe he just wanted to pick the moment he kept his word himself. Yesterday, after the game, everybody was crowded around him. Some people were comforting him. Others were repeating the score just loud enough for him to hear.

Monsieur Diatta had said:

"The ball will be handed over tomorrow, once everyone has calmed down."

The calm arrived this morning in the form of a courtyard full of people who claimed they just happened to be there.

Moussa, Idrissa, Amadou, Souleymane, Ibrahima, and Fatou were standing by the wall. Awa had planted herself in front of everybody as if she were the team's official representative.

Cheikh came out of the Fatys' house with his bag.

Malang walked behind him.

"We have to go," Cheikh said.

"Okay," I answered.

Nobody moved.

"What?"

Awa pointed at the bag.

"The ball."

"I know."

"Then give it."

"Awa," I whispered.

"What? He knows."

Malang looked at Cheikh.

"It's your word," he said.

Not: Give it to *them*.

Not: You lost.

Just that.

Cheikh opened his bag. He took out the training ball and held it against his hip.

"You scored," he said.

"Twice," Souleymane pointed out.

"The rule said once."

He held the ball out to me.



I took it.

It was heavier than I'd imagined. Or maybe all the people watching added some weight.

"Thanks," I said.

Cheikh looked surprised.

"You're thanking somebody who lost?"

"I'm thanking somebody who keeps his word."

He looked down.

"That was a good move for your second goal."

Souleymane coughed very loudly.

"Only the second one?"

"The first one too."

Moussa crossed his arms.

"You can say my name. It still works after a loss."

A shadow of a smile crossed Cheikh's face.

"Nice run, Moussa."

"Nice pass, Lamine," Fatou added.

“And nice goal, Idrissa,” said Amadou.

Idrissa was looking at the ground. I think he’d rather have scored in front of a hundred people than hear his name said in a small courtyard.

Cheikh put his bag back on his shoulder.

“I shouldn’t have called your stuff garbage,” he said.

It wasn’t a big apology. He didn’t mention all his other comments, or the way he had looked at us that first day.

But he had picked the exact bruise.

“No, you shouldn’t have,” I said.

“At the academy, if you mess up, somebody’s waiting to take your spot. If you come back to the village, everyone asks why. If you make it, they ask how far you’re going to go. You always have to prove you haven’t gone backward.”

He was staring at the ball in my hands.

“Your coach’s message?” I asked.

“They were picking the squad for a tournament. I’m a sub.”

Souleymane opened his mouth. For once, he decided not to say anything.

“Is that why you kept taking those shots over and over?”

Cheikh shrugged.

“A sub doesn’t have many mistakes to waste.”

I understood him better.

I didn’t forget everything.

Understanding someone doesn’t turn their words into kind words. It only shows you where those words came from.

“You still lost,” Awa said.

Everybody looked at her.

“What? It’s true.”

Cheikh burst out laughing.

A real laugh, not the one he used when he wanted to seem above us.

“Yes,” he said. “I still lost.”

He turned to me.

“Neutral field next time.”

“That was the rule.”

“And bring this ball. I want to see if it still knows how to roll straight.”

“Maybe it’ll learn to choose its team.”

We shook hands.

Not like best friends.

Not like enemies either.

After he left, we went to the field. We didn’t use the new ball right away. Idrissa wrote our names on it, very small, next to a seam. Fatou added the date and the score.

Souleymane wanted to write **CHAMPIONS OF BAMBALI**.

We explained to him that one game doesn’t make a championship.

He said the ball lacked ambition.

Before we played, I took out my red laces.

Moussa frowned.

“Did they break?”

“No.”

I had washed them the night before. One of the ends was starting to fray; Mom had helped me fix it.

I held them out to him.

“They’re yours.”

“I gave them to you.”

“You lent them to me.”

“Did I say that?”

“Not exactly.”

“Then keep them.”

“Are you sure?”

Moussa took one lace and slid it through his fingers.

“They finally taught you how to pass. Maybe you should stay on the treatment.”

I bumped him with my shoulder.

I put the laces back in my shoes.

They weren’t lucky.

They carried a story we both knew.

In the evening, I brought my journal to Baba.

He was sitting under the awning. His drum was resting beside him, covered.

“I picked a page,” I said.

He set his hands on his knees.

I sat down across from him and opened it to February 10.

THE FORGOTTEN NAME.

I read about the ceremony, the man who came in late, Baba’s finger stopped above the drumhead, and the rhythm I had picked up on the cover of the notebook.

I didn’t skip anything.

Baba didn’t correct the way I told it.

He didn’t ask for the other pages.



When I finished, he said:
“I didn’t know you had seen my fear.”
“I didn’t know it was fear.”
He took the cloth off his drum.
“Now you know.”
He played the pattern.

DOUM. DOUM-DOUM. PA.

I answered with my fingers on the new ball.

POC. POC-POC.

The two rhythms weren’t the same.
They didn’t need to be.

EPILOGUE

Poc, Doum, Poc

Sunday, March 17, 2024



Our Ramadan schedule didn't even last a week. That's already a lot for a schedule Baba and I made together.

On Wednesday, he was supposed to teach me the next part of Abdoulaye's line. Moussa showed up twenty minutes early for practice. I wanted to leave. Baba wanted to add twenty minutes the next day. Mom suggested we start by looking at the time written on the paper.

We were both wrong.

That calmed us down.

Since Ramadan started, the rhythm of the house has changed. Meals, sleep, visits, and practices don't happen at the same times anymore. The grownups in the family are fasting; for the younger ones, it depends on age, health, and what their parents have worked out with them. Every

morning Awa announces a new record, and she changes it before noon.

Today we only played late in the afternoon, and no long game. Monsieur Diatta reminded us that being exhausted isn't proof of being brave and that nobody wins by ignoring their body.

The new ball stays at Idrissa's house between practices. His mom has the best place to keep it, away from the little kids, the goats, and Souleymane.

"Why away from me?" Souleymane asked.

"Because you wanted to sleep with it," Idrissa said.

"It was a historic night."

The old patched ball lives at our house.

Awa adopted it.

She says that since it split three seams and survived, it can survive her shots. She put together a team with two girls from the neighborhood and Idrissa's little brother. They moved their goals farther from our field so they won't get in the way of our practices.

She won't let me give them orders.

I think she has studied my story very carefully.

This evening, Baba sat in the courtyard with his drum. I was juggling the old ball.

One.

Two.

Three.

On the fourth, the ball hit the seam and rolled under a chair.

Awa laughed.

"Professional player!"

“Go get your ball.”
 “You’re the one who lost it.”
 She was right again. It’s exhausting.
 I got it back and started over.
 Baba played a simple rhythm.

DOUM. DOUM. PA.

I let the ball bounce between the beats.



POC. DOUM. POC.

“Tell me about the second goal,” Baba said.
 “You were there.”
 “I want to hear how you tell it today.”
 I held the ball under my foot.
 “Idrissa blocks Cheikh’s shot.”
 Baba struck the drum once.

DOUM.

“Amadou catches the next one. Moussa gets open. Souleymane drags Malick into the middle. I wait for Cheikh to push the ball out.”

DOUM-DOUM.

“I take it. I give it to Moussa. He gives it back. Fadel comes out. I see Idrissa at the far post.”

I nudged the ball toward Awa.

She put her foot on it.

“And then?” Baba asked.

“I pass.”

Awa passed the ball back to me.

“And Idrissa scores!” she shouted.

“You weren’t in the play.”

“But I was there.”

Baba picked up the rhythm again.

He told me about Abdoulaye, the name I forgot at the very beginning of this journal. Not about a perfect hero. About a man in our family who knew a great many stories, but who sometimes asked someone else to finish when his memory stumbled.

“So he forgot things?” I asked.

“Like everyone.”

“Why didn’t you ever tell me that?”

“You never asked me.”

I suspect Baba had that answer ready for several weeks.

I still don’t know if I’ll become a professional soccer player.

I also don’t know what place Baba’s stories will have in my life when I’m his age.

Before, I thought you had to choose right away, like in front of a defender: left or right.

Now I think there's sometimes a third choice.

Lift your head.

See who's running with you.

Then pass the ball at the right moment.

Baba strikes the drum.

I let the ball drop.

It comes back up to my foot.

POC. DOUM. POC.

Words from Bambali



These notes go with the words and places in Lamine's journal. They're simple starting points, not a summary of all the cultures and languages of Senegal.

Auntie: a warm and respectful way to address an older woman, whether or not she is family.

Baba: the loving name Lamine's family uses for his father, Boubacar NDiop, who is a griot.

Bambali: a real village in southern Senegal, on the Casamance River, in the Sédhiou region. It's where Lamine lives, and it's the hometown of the soccer star Sadio Mané.

Boubou: a long, loose robe worn in many West African countries. People wear it in many styles, depending on the region, the family, and the occasion.

Bounkiling: a town in the Sédhiou region. Lamine's mom goes there to buy supplies for her business.

Casamance: the southern part of Senegal, south of the Gambia and connected to the rest of Senegal to the east. It includes the regions of Ziguinchor, Sédhiou, and Kolda.

Dakar: the capital of Senegal, on the Atlantic coast. Lamine's big brother Ousmane is learning to be a mechanic there, and Malang works there.

Doum and poc: sounds used in this story. *Doum* is a deep beat on Baba's drum; *poc* is the sound of a foot, or the ground, meeting the ball.

Friday prayers: the big weekly group prayer at the mosque, held on Friday in the early afternoon.

Griot: in many West African societies, a keeper of family memory. A griot knows family trees, tells history, and brings ceremonies to life with words and music. The knowledge is often passed down from parent to child.

Kapok tree: a huge West African tree with a wide trunk, often growing at the heart of a village.

Madame, Monsieur: French titles of address for women and men. French is the main language of instruction in Senegal, so students use these titles with their teachers.

Muezzin: the person who gives the call to prayer in Muslim communities.

Pagne: a length of cloth wrapped around the waist and worn as a skirt or as work clothes.

Pirogue: a long boat used for fishing and travel on the water. Its shape and construction vary by place and use.

Ramadan: a month of the Muslim calendar devoted to fasting, prayer, sharing, and community. How people take part can depend on age, health, family, and circumstances.

Sédhiou: the region of southern Senegal where Bambali is. Its main town is also called Sédhiou.

Soccer academy: a program where young players get regular, organized training, often alongside their schooling. Getting into an academy doesn't guarantee a professional career.

Yaye: a Wolof word that means “mom.” The whole household, grandchildren included, calls Baba’s mother Yaye Khady.

Ziguinchor: the biggest city in the Casamance and the capital of the region with the same name. People go there for travel, school, business, and services.

A Note on the Story



Lamine, his family, his friends, and their neighbors are made up. Bambali, however, is a real village in the Middle Casamance, on the Casamance River, in the Sédhiou region. It's the hometown of the soccer star Sadio Mané, who has paid for a hospital, school facilities, and the municipal stadium's new artificial turf, inaugurated in January 2024. The characters in the plot are fictional. Sadio Mané is mentioned as a real public figure.

In Senegal, as in other West African countries, griots are the keepers of family memory. They know family trees, tell history, and bring big ceremonies to life with words and music. This knowledge is often handed down from one generation to the next.

Lots of young Senegalese people dream of becoming professional soccer players, and academies take in promising players every year. Very few of them will make a career of it, which is why many academies also require their players to stay in school.

Lamine's journal runs from February 5 to March 17, 2024. That year, Ramadan began in Senegal on March 11 or 12, depending on the community.

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD

My Corner of the World follows four fictional young narrators in four countries on three continents. Each book can be read on its own, and they speak to each other in surprising ways.

Sokha's Diary: The Road to the Bell

The Drum and the Ball: Lamine's Journal

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